Haligric Research Integration Series

The Path of the Twelve

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of Alevism and the Bektashi Order of Anatolia

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Turkey's largest religious minority does not pray in mosques, does not fast during Ramadan, and does not separate men from women in worship — and the state that governs them still refuses, a century into the republic, to formally recognize any of it as a distinct faith.

This is Alevism: a heterodox Anatolian tradition of Shia devotion to the Twelve Imams, Sufi interior discipline, and pre-Islamic Turkic and local custom, worshipped through a nighttime gathering called the cem, where women and men dance together in a slow, turning rite called the semah.

Its closest institutional relative, the Bektashi Sufi order, once stood at the spiritual center of the Ottoman Empire's own army — until the sultan who feared that army's power banned the order outright and drove its leadership into exile.

This is also, this year, a live and unresolved reckoning with a 1993 arson attack that killed thirty-five people at an Alevi cultural festival.

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Introduction — The Path of the Twelve

Alevism is a heterodox religious tradition, distinct from both Sunni and Twelver Shia Islam, practiced predominantly among Turkish and Kurdish communities in Anatolia and, through migration, across the Turkish and Kurdish diaspora in Europe. Estimates of the Alevi population in Turkey range widely, from roughly ten to twenty-five million people, making Alevis by most estimates Turkey's largest religious minority, concentrated historically in central and eastern Anatolia, with the province of Tunceli (Dersim) regarded as a particular cultural and demographic center.

Alevism combines devotion to the Twelve Imams central to Shia Islam, Sufi interior spiritual discipline transmitted especially through the Bektashi order, and pre-Islamic Anatolian Turkic and local Anatolian folk religious elements, into a synthesis that diverges sharply from both mainstream Sunni and mainstream Shia practice in its ritual, law, and community structure. The Bektashi order — a distinct but closely related Sufi tariqa founded by the thirteenth-century saint Hacı Bektaş Veli — is often discussed alongside Alevism under the combined label 'Alevi-Bektashi,' reflecting their deep historical entanglement despite genuinely separate origins and institutional structures.

Origins — Hacı Bektaş Veli and the Turkic Anatolian Synthesis

Hacı Bektaş Veli, a thirteenth-century Anatolian saint whose spiritual lineage is traced back to the Central Asian Sufi master Ahmad Yasawi, is revered as the founding figure of the Bektashi order and, by extension, as a central spiritual authority within Alevi tradition, even though Alevism's own roots as a distinct rural Anatolian religious community developed somewhat independently alongside and after him.

Alevi and Bektashi tradition alike trace their theological center to devotion to Ali ibn Abi Talib, the Prophet Muhammad's cousin and son-in-law, and to the Twelve Imams descended from him, a devotion shared with Twelver Shia Islam but expressed through a distinctly Anatolian ritual, poetic, and communal framework rather than through the clerical and legal structures of Iranian or Iraqi Shia practice.

Theology — Hakk, the Twelve Imams, and the Four Doors

Central to Alevi-Bektashi theology is the concept of Hakk (the Truth/Reality, one of the names of God), understood as an essence carried within every human being — a theological position that grounds the tradition's strong emphasis on human equality and its relatively unusual (within an Islamic-derived tradition) openness to gender egalitarianism in worship and social life.

The Bektashi teaching of Dört Kapı Kırk Makam, the 'Four Doors, Forty Stations,' attributed to Hacı Bektaş Veli, describes the spiritual path as a progression through four sequential doors, each containing ten stations: Şeriat (Sharia, the door of religious law and outward worship), Tarikat (the Sufi path of discipleship to a spiritual guide and inner discipline), Marifet (gnosis, or direct spiritual knowledge, including the station of 'knowing oneself'), and Hakikat (Truth, the culminating door of direct experiential encounter with the divine, marked by radical non-judgment and compassion extended to all of humanity, traditionally described as encompassing 'seventy-two nations'). This structure closely parallels, while remaining textually and institutionally distinct from, the maqamat (stations) framework found in the broader Sufi tradition covered elsewhere in this series, reflecting Bektashism's genuine roots within the wider Sufi world even as Alevi practice diverges from it in law and ritual.

The Cem Ceremony and the Semah

The cem is the central Alevi collective ritual, a communal worship gathering that can last up to five hours and is led by a dede, a hereditary religious specialist belonging to a recognized ocak (spiritual lineage), who guides the community through a structured sequence of twelve ritual services (on iki hizmet). These services include the recitation of sacred poetry (much of it drawn from Alevi-Bektashi poet-saints), the resolution of community disputes brought before the assembled congregation, and the communal sharing of consecrated food (lokma).

The semah, one of the twelve services performed within the cem, is a set of rhythmic, turning body movements performed together by men and women without gender separation — a striking distinction from most Islamic-derived ritual practice — understood as both an aesthetic and a genuinely mystical technology for transmitting Alevi spiritual understanding across generations, structurally comparable in spiritual function, though not in form, to the Mevlevi sema described elsewhere in this series' Sufism volume.

Alevi religious practice differs from both Sunni and mainstream Shia observance in several fundamental respects: worship takes place in a cemevi rather than a mosque, the five daily prayers and ritual ablution are not practiced, fasting is observed during the month of Muharram (commemorating the martyrdom of Imam Hussein) rather than during Ramadan, and the consumption of alcohol is not prohibited — differences that have historically fueled both internal Alevi self-understanding as a distinct faith community and external Sunni suspicion or hostility toward the tradition.

Musahiplik and Sacred Companionship

Musahiplik ('spiritual companionship') is a distinctive Alevi institution in which two married couples formally bind themselves together in a lifelong ritual kinship relationship, taking on mutual responsibility for each other's moral and spiritual conduct and, traditionally, becoming ineligible to marry across the two families for several generations, functioning as an extended form of chosen sacred family alongside blood kinship.

This institution, together with the dede's role in mediating community disputes during the cem itself, reflects a broader Alevi understanding of religious practice as inseparable from social ethics and communal accountability — worship and moral governance are treated as a single, unified religious act rather than separate domains.

Key Figures and Sacred Texts

Pir Sultan Abdal, a sixteenth-century Alevi poet-saint whose devotional and often politically defiant verse remains central to Alevi liturgical and cultural life, is honored annually at cultural festivals across Turkey; it was precisely such a festival, held in his honor in the city of Sivas, that became the site of the 1993 massacre described in the closing section below, a historical irony that has permanently bound his memory to that atrocity in contemporary Alevi consciousness.

The Buyruk ('The Order' or 'Commandment'), a body of religious instructional texts attributed variously to the Twelve Imams and to later Alevi-Bektashi saints, functions as a central body of Alevi religious literature, interpreted and taught by dedes within their communities rather than through a formal centralized clerical hierarchy. The Bektashi order itself, following Hacı Bektaş Veli's death, developed under successive spiritual leaders into a formal Sufi tariqa with its own initiatory structure, distinct from — though closely allied with — the rural, hereditary ocak-based structure of Alevi community religious life.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

The semah, beyond its ceremonial role within the cem, functions for many practitioners as an embodied spiritual and psychological practice in its own right — a physically disciplined, communally shared movement meditation whose sustained turning and rhythmic coordination is described by practitioners in terms very similar to other embodied contemplative traditions, including the Mevlevi sema.

The musahiplik companionship bond and the dede's role in communal dispute resolution together function as an ongoing, structured system of social and emotional support integrated directly into religious practice, reflecting a broader Alevi understanding that individual wellbeing is inseparable from right relationship within a bonded religious community rather than a matter of private, individual practice alone.

Legacy and Influence

The Bektashi order rose to particular historical prominence in the fifteenth century through its close spiritual association with the Ottoman Empire's elite Janissary infantry corps, becoming, for centuries, one of the most politically significant Sufi orders in the empire; this same association led directly to its downfall when Sultan Mahmud II, having crushed the Janissary corps itself in 1826, banned the Bektashi order throughout the empire specifically because of its Janissary ties, exiling or executing many of its dervishes and destroying numerous Bektashi lodges (tekkes).

The order gradually recovered during the later Tanzimat reform period, only to be shut down again in Turkey in 1925 under Mustafa Kemal Atatürk's broader suppression of Sufi orders; its leadership subsequently relocated to Albania, where the Bektashi World Headquarters remains seated in Tirana today, currently led by Baba Mondi as the eighth Dedebaba in an unbroken succession from Hacı Bektaş Veli. Alevi cultural and religious organizations across the Turkish and European diaspora continue to press for the tradition's fuller formal recognition, and Alevi-Bektashi poetry, particularly that of Pir Sultan Abdal, remains a significant and actively performed part of Turkish and Kurdish musical and literary culture well beyond the Alevi community itself.

Persecution and the Fight for Recognition — Controversies and Fairness

Despite constituting Turkey's largest religious minority, Alevis remain, as of this writing, formally unrecognized as a distinct religious community under Turkish law; cemevis are not granted the same official legal status as mosques, and Alevi children are required to attend mandatory Sunni-oriented religious education classes in Turkish public schools, a policy that has been repeatedly challenged, including before the European Court of Human Rights, without full resolution.

On July 2, 1993, a mob set fire to the Madımak Hotel in Sivas during a cultural festival honoring the Alevi poet Pir Sultan Abdal, killing thirty-five people, including thirty-three festival attendees and two hotel workers, in what has become the single most significant and symbolically weighted act of anti-Alevi violence in modern Turkish history. Although many of those responsible received life sentences, statute-of-limitations provisions allowed a number of prosecutions to be dismissed, and victims' families, arguing the massacre should be treated as a crime against humanity exempt from such limitations, filed an appeal with Turkey's Constitutional Court in 2014 — a case that took twelve years to resolve.

In July 2026, Turkey's Constitutional Court unanimously ruled that the state had failed to conduct an effective investigation into the deaths and ordered compensation for victims' relatives, a decision that acknowledged state failure but did not reopen dismissed prosecutions; the extraordinary length of the delay led three victims' families to simultaneously file parallel cases with the European Court of Human Rights in June 2026, and critics continue to describe the case's overall handling as emblematic of a persistent, unresolved pattern of institutional impunity in violence against the Alevi community.

Closing

The Bektashi order's world headquarters now sits not in Turkey but in Tirana, Albania, still led by a Dedebaba in an unbroken line from Hacı Bektaş Veli himself.

The cemevis where Alevis actually worship are, as of this writing, still not recognized under Turkish law with the same status as a mosque — and in July 2026, Turkey's own Constitutional Court found that the state had failed for over three decades to deliver justice for the thirty-five people burned to death at Sivas in 1993.

Grand rising to the people of the path of the Twelve — the semah still turns, and the accounting for Sivas is, this year, still being demanded.